space. The concept of field is inevitable in understanding the behaviour of charges.

iii) The unit of gravitational field is newton per kilogram (N/kg) or m s^{-2}.

6.2.2 Superposition principle for Gravitational field

Consider 'n' particles of masses $m_1, m_2, \ldots m_n$, distributed in space at positions $\vec{r}_1, \vec{r}_2, \vec{r}_3 \ldots$ etc, with respect to point P. The total gravitational field at a point P due to all the masses is given by the vector sum of the gravitational field due to the individual masses (Figure 6.11). This principle is known as superposition of gravitational fields.

$$\vec{E}_{total} = \vec{E}_1 + \vec{E}_2 + \ldots \vec{E}_n$$

$$= -\frac{Gm_1}{r_1^2}\hat{r}_1 - \frac{Gm_2}{r_2^2}\hat{r}_2 - \ldots - \frac{Gm_n}{r_n^2}\hat{r}_n$$

$$= -\sum_{i=1}^{n} \frac{Gm_i}{r_i^2}\hat{r}_i . \qquad (6.20)$$

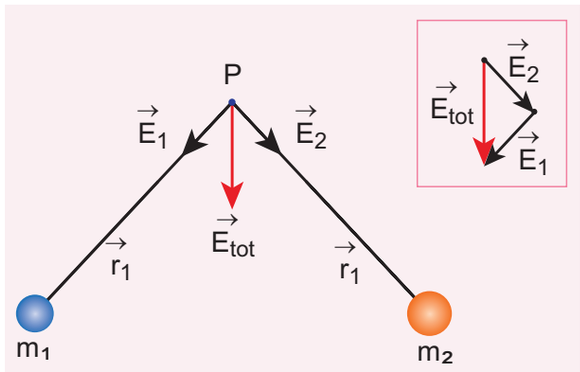
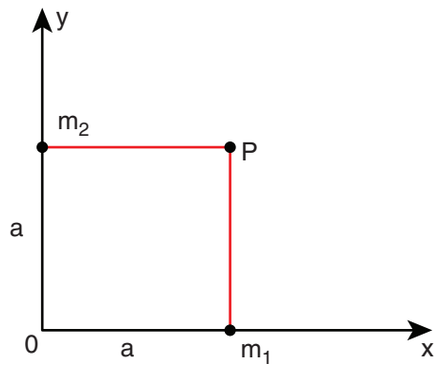


Figure 6.11 Superposition of two gravitational field intensities giving resultant field.

Instead of discrete masses, if we have continuous distribution of a total mass M, then the gravitational field at a point P is calculated using the method of integration.

EXAMPLE 6.3

(a) Two particles of masses m_1 *and* m_2 are placed along the x and y axes respectively at a distance 'a' from the origin. Calculate the gravitational field at a point P shown in figure below.



Solution

Gravitational field due to m_1 at a point P is given by,

$$\vec{E}_1 = -\frac{Gm_1}{a^2}\hat{j}$$

Gravitational field due to m_2 at the point p is given by,

$$\vec{E}_2 = -\frac{Gm_2}{a^2}\hat{i}$$

$$\vec{E}_{total} = -\frac{Gm_1}{a^2}\hat{j} - \frac{Gm_2}{a^2}\hat{i}$$

$$= -\frac{G}{a^2}\left(m_1\hat{j} + m_2\hat{i}\right)$$

The direction of the total gravitational field is determined by the relative value of m_1 and m_2.

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